



Long-tailed chinchilla

Chinchilla lanigera

- ↔ 8–9 in (22–23 cm)
- 📍 SW. South America
- ⊗ Critically endangered

Restricted to the mountains of central Chile, the chinchilla has been hunted for centuries for its thick, soft, silver-gray fur, essential for survival in its cold mountain habitat. Although widely bred in captivity, it is now very rare in the wild, where it lives in colonies of 100 or more in rocky terrain, sheltering in crevices. Active at night, it nibbles grass, leaves, and other plant material, often holding them in its forepaws like a squirrel.

Argentine plains viscacha

Lagostomus maximus

- ↔ 2 in (5 cm)
- 📍 C. and S. South America
- ⊗ Common

Plains viscachas have mainly gray fur with badgerlike black-and-white facial stripes. They live in noisy colonies of 20–50, in extensive burrow systems that are used for many generations. They stay below ground during the day, coming out to feed at night. They often return with sticks, stones, and even bones, which they pile up around the entrances to their burrows.

Desmarest's hutia

Capromys pilorides

- ↔ 22–24 in (55–60 cm)
- 📍 Locally common
- ⊗ Caribbean

Found only in Cuba, this big, stocky, short-legged rodent resembles an oversized vole. It has sharp, curved claws with which it grips the bark as it climbs trees in search of nutritious leaves, fruit, soft bark, and the occasional small animal such as a lizard. In northern Cuba, this animal lives mainly among coastal mangrove forests, but it favors more open habitats in other locations.

Naked mole rat

Heterocephalus glaber

- ↔ 3 in (7.6 cm)
- 📍 E. Africa
- ⊗ Common

This rodent is specialized for living underground, with very sparse hair on its wrinkled, pale skin, tiny eyes, and big incisor teeth used for tunneling through the dry East African soil. It lives in large colonies,

organized in a similar way to ant colonies, with one breeding queen, two or three breeding males, and up to 80 nonbreeding workers of both sexes. The female workers are reproductively suppressed, but if the queen dies, one of them takes over and develops the ability to breed.

large incisor
tooth



Coypu

Myocastor coypus

- ↔ 19–23 in (47–58 cm)
- 📍 S. South America
- ⊗ Common

The beaverlike coypu is adapted for swimming, with webbed hindfeet and eyes and ears set high on its head, clear of the water. In its native South American wetlands, it lives in family groups in riverbank burrows and feeds on water plants. It has been farmed for its dense brown fur in many other parts of the world, where escaped animals have established breeding colonies in the wild.

Springhare

Pedetes capensis

- ↔ 11–16 in (27–40 cm)
- 📍 C. and E. Africa to Southern Africa
- ⊗ Common

Looking like a cross between a rabbit and a kangaroo, the springhare lives in the deserts of southeastern Africa, where it has a mixed diet of seeds, bulbs, plant stems, and insects. It can hop fast on its long hindlegs, covering up to 10 ft (3 m) in a single bound, but despite this, it rarely travels far from the burrows where it hides during the day. Its speed is mainly for defense, allowing it to bolt for cover at the first hint of danger.

Other species

- **Alpine chipmunk**
Tamias alpinus » p56
- **Alpine marmot**
Marmota marmota » p160
- **American beaver**
Castor canadensis » p41
- **Black-tailed prairie dog**
Cynomys ludovicianus » p48
- **Cape porcupine**
Hystrix africaeaustralis » p231
- **Capybara**
Hydrochoerus hydrochaeris » p101
- **Eurasian red squirrel**
Sciurus vulgaris » p142

- **Northern viscacha**
Lagidium peruanum » p109
- **Patagonian mara**
Dolichotis patagonum » p117
- **Siberian flying squirrel**
Pteromys volans » p285

